

Modalism Denial

doc-modalism-denial

Theology Proper · Trinity · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in
Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

The Father, Son, and Holy Spirit are three distinct, coeternal Persons sharing one divine essence, distinct in personhood, not three modes or roles successively assumed by one Person.

In plain language

The Greek of these passages shows the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit acting at the same time and speaking to one another, not one figure putting on three masks in turn. At the baptism in Matthew 3 verses 16 and 17 the Son comes up out of the water, the Spirit of God descends like a dove and rests on him, and a voice from heaven says, This is my beloved Son. The voice uses the third-person word this and the first-person word my in the same sentence, so two persons are in view at once. In John 17 the Son prays to the Father using the second-person you, asks to share glory he had with the Father before the world existed, and says you sent me, which needs a sender different from the one sent. One person cannot ask that he glorify himself with glory shared with himself. In John 14 verse 16 the Son says he will ask the Father to give another Helper of the same kind, the Spirit, a third subject distinct from both the speaker and the one asked. The Greek word for another Helper, "Helper, Advocate" (parakletos), appears only five times, and its one other use calls Jesus himself our Helper, so the another is plainly a different person. In Matthew 28 verse 19 baptism is into one singular name, but the name is unpacked as of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit, with the word "the" repeated three times, holding one name together with three distinct persons. John 1 verse 1 places the Word face to face with God and then says the Word was God, distinguishing the two while sharing one nature. The strongest texts for a single-person view are the one-God verses, like John 10 verse 30, I and the Father are one. But there the Greek word for one, "one" (hen), is the neuter (genderless) form, which means one thing such as one essence, and the verb are is plural, which needs two subjects. The Hebrew "one" (echad) in Deuteronomy 6 verse 4 likewise can mean a compound oneness, as in one flesh of two people. So the words clearly settle one God in essence and three distinct persons, and they leave no room for one person in three successive modes.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0259	της	echad	one	970
G0027	ἀγαπητός	agapētos	beloved	61
G0228	ἀληθινός	alēthinos	true	28
G0243	ἄλλος	allos	another	154
G0649	ἀποστέλλω	apostellō	to send	132
G1325	δίδωμι	didōmi	to give	
G1391	δόξα	doxa	glory	

G1392	δοξάζω	doxazō	to glorify	61
G1473	ἐγώ	egō	I/we	2,572
G1520	εἷς	heis	one	342
G2041	ἔργον	ergon	work	
G2316	θεός	theos	God	1,307
G2597	καταβαίνω	katabainō	to come/go down	
G3056	λόγος	logos	word	330
G3686	ὄνομα	onoma	name	229
G3778	οὗτος	houtos	this/he/she/it	
G3844	παρά	para	from/with/beside	
G3870	παράκλητος	paraklētos	to plead/comfort	5
G3962	πατήρ	patēr	father	413
G4151	πνεῦμα	pneuma	spirit/breath	379
G4314	πρός	pros	to/with	696
G4771	σύ	sy	you	2,894
G5207	υἱός	huios	son	375

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

The lexical pattern across the anchor passages is decided by grammar, not by any single word. The three are repeatedly the simultaneous subjects of distinct verbs and the parties of reciprocal pronoun address, which a one-person-in-sequence reading cannot accommodate. At the baptism (Matthew 3:16-17) the Son ascends ("he went up" (anebe), 3rd person singular, a completed past action), the Spirit descends upon him ("coming down upon him" (katabainon ep auton)), and a heavenly voice says "this is my beloved Son" (houtos estin ho huios mou), third-person demonstrative ("this") plus first-person possessive ("my") in one breath. In John 17 the Son in the first person ("I" (ego)) addresses the Father in the second person ("you" (se, su)) and says "you sent" (apesteilas), which requires a sender other than the sent. John 14:16 has the Son ask the Father to give "another Helper of the same kind" (allon parakleton). John 1:1 sets "the Word with God" (ho logos pros ton theon), the preposition "toward, with, face-to-face" (pros) with the accusative form (the direct-object form) "the God" (ton theon) marking face-to-face relation, alongside "the Word was God" (theos en ho logos), shared nature. The one-God texts (John 10:30 "one" (hen), Deuteronomy 6:4 "one" (echad)) assert unity of essence, not identity of person, since "one" (hen) is neuter (the genderless form) with a plural verb "we are" (esmen) and "one" (echad) covers compound unity. The pattern is dense and spans multiple authors and genres.

Scripture

Matt.3.16 · for · genre: gospel · figures: simile

Key terms. G4151 πνεῦμα, G2316 θεός, G2597 καταβαίνω

Reasoning. Three distinct subjects act in the same moment. The Son ascends from the water ("he went up" (anebe), 3rd person singular, a completed past action (aorist) of "to go up" (anabaino)), the Spirit of God ("Spirit of God" (pneuma theou)) descends as a dove and rests upon him (the participle (verb-form acting like an adjective) "coming down" (katabainon) with "upon" (epi) and the accusative form (the direct-object form) "him" (auton)), and the heavens are opened above ("were opened" (enedichthesan), 3rd person plural passive ("were-done-to" form)). The spatial separation of descending Spirit, ascending Son, and opened "heavens" (ouranoi), plus the third-person reference to "him" (auton), exclude a single subject occupying all three roles at once.

Matt.3.17 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3962 πατήρ, G5207 υἱός, G0027 ἀγαπητός

Reasoning. A voice "from the heavens" (ek ton ouranon) declares "this is my beloved Son" (houtos estin ho huios mou ho agapetos). The third-person demonstrative "this" (houtos) (parsed nominative (subject form) singular masculine) points to the one still in the water, while the first-person possessive "my" (mou) belongs to the speaking voice. Two distinct grammatical persons are simultaneously in view, which rules out one person speaking of himself as if of another.

John.17.1 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3962 πατήρ, G5207 υἱός, G1392 δοξάζω

Reasoning. The Son addresses "Father" (pater) in the vocative (the form used for direct address), asks "glorify your Son" (doxason sou ton huion) (2nd person imperative, a command directed at "you"), and continues "so that the Son may glorify you" (hina ho huios doxase se) (3rd person subjunctive, an "in order that" form, with the 2nd person accusative "you" (se)). The mutual-glorification clause needs two distinct subjects. A single person cannot intelligibly ask that he glorify himself so that he might glorify himself.

John.17.3 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G2316 θεός, G0228 ἀληθινός, G0649 ἀποστέλλω

Reasoning. The Son distinguishes the Father as "the only true God" (ton monon alethinon theon) while naming himself Jesus Christ "whom you sent" (hon apesteilas). The verb "you sent" (apesteilas) is 2nd person singular, a completed past action (aorist), and a sending requires a sender other than the one sent. The acknowledgment formula sets the two referents side by side without collapsing them into one.

John.17.5 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3962 πατήρ, G3844 παρά, G1391 δόξα

Reasoning. The Son asks "glorify me, you, Father, alongside yourself with the glory that I was having before the world existed alongside you" (doxason me su, pater, para seauto te doxe he eichon pro tou ton kosmon einai para soi). The preposition "alongside, beside" (para) with the reflexive "yourself" (seauto) and then "alongside you" (para soi), together with the ongoing past tense "I was having" (eichon), locate two parties sharing glory before the world existed. A construction of shared glory held alongside another excludes successive single-person modes.

John.14.16 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G0243 ἄλλος, G3870 παράκλητος, G3962 πατήρ

Reasoning. The Son says "and I will ask the Father and he will give you another Helper" (kago erotes ton patera kai allon parakleton dosei hymin). The adjective "another of the same kind" (allos) (accusative (direct-object form) singular masculine) ranges as another of the same kind, presupposing the Son is himself a "Helper, Advocate" (parakletos) (the only other use of the noun, 1 John 2:1, calls Jesus our "Helper" (parakletos)) and that the coming one is a distinct subject. The clause holds three grammatical subjects: the speaking Son ("and I" (kago), 1st person), the petitioned Father, and the given other Helper ("he will give" (dosei), 3rd person).

Matt.28.19 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3686 ὄνομα, G3962 πατήρ, G5207 υἱός, G4151 πνεῦμα

Reasoning. The baptismal formula uses the singular "name" (onoma) (accusative (direct-object form) singular neuter (genderless form)) with three articulated genitives ("of-the-X" forms each carrying the word "the") joined by "and" (kai), "of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit" (tou patros kai tou huiou kai tou hagiou pneumatos). The single "name" (onoma) binds the three under one name, while the iterated article construction ("the ... the ... the" (tou ... tou ... tou)) keeps three distinct referents. The grammar holds unity of name together with distinctness of persons in one clause.

John.1.1 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3056 λόγος, G4314 πρὸς, G2316 θεός

Reasoning. "In the beginning was the Word, and the Word was with God, and the Word was God" (En arche en ho logos, kai ho logos en pros ton theon, kai theos en ho logos). The preposition "toward, with, face-to-face" (pros) with the accusative (direct-object form) "the God" (ton theon) (parsed accusative singular masculine) marks a face-to-face relation between two parties. The "Word" (Logos) and "the God" (ho theos) are at once distinguished ("with the God" (pros ton theon)) and identified in nature (the anarthrous (without the article "the") predicate nominative (the noun completing a "X is Y" statement) "God" (theos) before the verb). The relational "toward, with" (pros) excludes one subject relating to itself in succession.

John.1.2 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G3778 οὗτος, G4314 πρὸς, G2316 θεός

Reasoning. "This one was in the beginning with God" (Houtos en en arche pros ton theon) restates the same simultaneous, eternal "toward, with" (pros) relation. The ongoing past tense "was" (en) stresses continuity, not a succession of modes. Two distinct referents stand face to face from the beginning.

John.17.4 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1392 δοξάζω, G1325 δίδωμι, G2041 ἔργον

Reasoning. "I glorified you on the earth, having completed the work that you have given me to do" (Ego se edoxasa epi tes ges, to ergon teleiosas ho dedokas moi hina poieso). The personal pronouns "I" (ego) (1st person nominative (subject form)) and "you" (se) (2nd person accusative (direct-object form)) with the giver-receiver verbs "you have given" (dedokas) (a completed action whose result still stands (perfect tense), 2nd person) and "I might do" (poieso) (1st person) plant two enduring subjects. The earthly work was given by one and completed by the other. In this grammar one party cannot give a work to itself.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
John.1.1	John.1.18	tsk	1
John.1.1	John.10.30	tsk	1
John.1.1	John.1.2	tsk	1
Matt.3.16	Isa.11.2	tsk	1
John.17.5	John.17.24	tsk	1
John.17.3	John.14.9	tsk	1
John.17.2	John.3.35	tsk	1
Matt.28.19	Matt.3.16	tsk	1
Matt.3.17	Matt.12.18	tsk	1

Complicating texts

John.10.30 · addressed

"I and the Father are one" (ego kai ho pater hen esmen). Queried morphology confirms "one" (hen) is parsed nominative (subject form) singular neuter (the genderless form, lemma "one" (heis)), not the masculine "one" (heis) that personal identity would require, so it asserts unity of one thing (essence, will, work) rather than collapse into one person. The verb "we are" (esmen) is 1st person plural and needs two subjects. The clause therefore affirms unity of essence with plurality of persons, the opposite of a one-person reading. This is the strongest one-person-only proof text and the grammar of the numeral and the verb is what settles it.

Deut.6.4 · addressed

The Shema (the Jewish confession beginning "Hear, O Israel") uses "one" (echad) (H259, queried at 970 occurrences across the Hebrew canon). "One" (echad) covers compound unity, for example "one flesh" (basar echad), of two persons in Genesis 2:24 ("one" (echad) confirmed present there by query). The Shema fixes the doctrine to one God and one essence but the word "one" (echad) does not by itself require one person, so the New Testament data above unfolds distinction within that one essence.

John.14.9 · addressed

"the one having seen me has seen the Father" (ho heorakos eme heoraken ton patera). The see-the-Father-in-the-Son language rests on the Son being the revealer and exact representation of the Father (compare John 1:18), not on identity of person. The very clause keeps "me" (eme) and "the Father" (ton patera) as two grammatical referents, so it does not support one person in two modes.

Isa.9.6 · addressed

Isaiah 9:6 in English is 9:5 in the queried Masoretic (the standard Hebrew text tradition) versification. The title rendered Everlasting Father is "father" (av) (H1) plus "perpetuity, eternity" (ad) (H5703), a Hebrew idiom of the form Father-of-X meaning founder or possessor of X (here Father of eternity, or eternal Father to his people). It is a messianic epithet of the child, not an equation of the persons of Father and Son, and it stands alongside "Mighty God" (el gibbor), in the same line. Read under "comparing Scripture with Scripture" (analogia scripturae) with the Father and Son distinction in Matthew 3:16-17 and John 17.

Concordance traversed

G3962, G5207, G4151, G0243, G3870, G3686, G3056, G4314, G2316, G4771, G1473, G1520, G1392, G0649, G0027, G0228, H0259

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

matt-28-19-baptismal-formula at Matt.28.19: impact none. A short form (in my name) is alleged only from a handful of patristic (early Church writer) citations and appears in no Greek manuscript. The triadic (three-part) "name" (onoma) phrase "of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit" (tou patros kai tou huiou kai tou hagiou pneumatos) is the unanimous manuscript reading and the SBLGNT (a critical edition of the Greek New Testament) text queried here carries it.

john-1-18-monogenes at John.1.18: impact none. "one-of-a-kind God" (monogenes theos) versus "one-of-a-kind Son" (monogenes huios). Either reading keeps a Son distinct from the Father, since "one-of-a-kind" (monogenes) stands in relation to "the Father" (ho pater) named in the same verse. The distinction of persons does not turn on which reading wins.

john-14-16-word-order at John.14.16: impact none. Minor word-order variants do not touch the "another Helper" (allon parakleton) clause or the three-party grammar ("and I will ask" (kago erotes), the Father, "he will give" (dosei)).

No anchor for this question falls inside the ingested ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) apparatus window (3 John 1:1 to 1:15), so no CBGM-published (the Coherence-Based Genealogical Method, used by the ECM editors) apparatus was consulted. The variant survey reflects standard NA28 (the Nestle-Aland 28th edition Greek New Testament) and INTF (the Institute for New Testament Textual Research) transcript signal only, hence shadow status.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. analogia_scripturae, monotheism_constraint

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

trinitarian_distinction: supported · Reads the three as distinct subjects within one essence. The grammar of simultaneity and reciprocal address (Matthew 3:16-17, John 17 first and second person interplay, John 14:16 "another Helper" (allon parakleton)) plus the unity texts (John 10:30 neuter (genderless) "one" (hen) with plural "we are" (esmen), Matthew 28:19 single "name" (onoma) over three articulated genitives ("of-the-X" forms)) jointly fit only this reading. This is the lens the lexical data most directly sustains.

modalism: incompatible · Holds that one person plays Father, Son, and Spirit successively. Its strongest texts are the one-God statements (Deuteronomy 6:4 "one" (echad), Isaiah 44:6, John 10:30 I and the Father are one) and identity statements (John 14:9, he who has seen me has seen the Father). But those very verses keep two grammatical referents ("me" (eme) and "the Father" (ton patera)) and use a neuter (genderless) "one" (hen) with a plural verb, while the baptism puts the three on stage at the same moment and "you sent" (apesteilas) requires a sender distinct from the sent. Successive single-person modes cannot produce simultaneous reciprocal address.

tritheism: also_incompatible · States its strongest case from the genuine threeness of subjects. But Matthew 28:19 binds the three under a singular "name" (onoma) and John 10:30 binds Father and Son under neuter (genderless) "one" (hen), unity of essence. The data require oneness of essence together with distinctness of persons, not three gods.

ontological_subordinationism: not_required · Its strongest case is the sending and obedience language ("you sent" (apesteilas), the given work in John 17:4). But that language is functional and economic, and John 17:5 places the Son in shared pre-creation glory "alongside" (para) the Father ("alongside you" (para soi), "alongside yourself" (para seauto)), which blocks a necessary inference of lesser being from the sending vocabulary.

The reading rests on coordinated grammar across genres and authors: synoptic baptism narrative, the Johannine high-priestly prayer, the Johannine prologue, and a dominical (spoken by the Lord) command. "Comparing Scripture with Scripture" (analogia scripturae) binds the unity texts and the distinction texts without collapsing either. The decisive engine is grammatical, distinct persons addressing and being sent by one another at the same time, not the meaning of any single word.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. How does the New Testament vocabulary and grammar describe the relation of the Father, the Son, and the Holy Spirit. Are they presented as one person taking three successive modes or roles, as three distinct persons sharing one divine essence, as three separate gods, or as some other pattern.

The original stem is framed as a denial of the one-person-in-three-modes position, naming that position as the foil, so it encodes its own conclusion. The neutralized form asks the lexical question without preloading any answer. The verdict is still derived on the original framing. The queried grammar yields three simultaneous, mutually addressed subjects within one shared name and essence, so the original proposition lands true, but the loaded framing is acknowledged here.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.3.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Matt.28.19

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.1.1
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.10.30
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.14.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	John.17.4
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Deut.6.4
interlinear	MACULA-Hebrew	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Isa.9.6
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0243
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3870
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G4314
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G1520
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	John.1.1
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Matt.28.19

License audit

NOT SAFE TO PUBLISH

Reason. The Hebrew morphology for the complicating texts Deuteronomy 6:4 ("one" (echad)) and Isaiah 9:6 ("father" (av) plus "perpetuity" (ad)) was read from MACULA-Hebrew, licensed CC-BY-NC-4.0, which prohibits commercial bulk redistribution. The file cannot be bulk-published while it relies on MACULA-Hebrew. The Greek grammar from MorphGNT-morphology, the lexical entries from STEP Bible-TBESG, and the TSK cross-refs are all redistributable.

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Flags

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